space to breathe

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/53158174.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Melog (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Fluff, Late Night Conversations

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2024-01-19 Words: 2,498 Chapters: 1/1

space to breathe

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/53158174.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Melog (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Fluff, Late Night Conversations

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2024-01-19 Words: 2,498 Chapters: 1/1

space to breathe

by hopelessgemini

Summary

she finds adora leaning against the railing of the balcony, chin resting in her hands. she looks half-asleep, and the wind is blowing loose strands of hair across her face and absolutely ruining that ponytail she insists on wearing to bed. in the moonlight, she looks almost made of silver. there are dark circles under her eyes and the faint smudges of tear tracks catching the light, and despite it all catra has never been more in love with her than she is right now.

"good morning," she says.

adora startles a little, lifting her head from her hands, but she doesn't turn to look at her. this should not be worrying, but catra is running on three and a half broken hours of sleep and the deep intrinsic sense that she's done something horrifically wrong, so of course she takes it a little personally. she tucks it away between her ribs and barrels on.

"you woke me up."

or, adora, catra, and the stars. written for the spop flex secret solstice gift exchange for queenmillicentofbystander!!

Notes

surfaces covered in floodwater not to be one of those ao3 authors who cites an earth-shattering event as the reason for a late fic but we had some bad storms in the uk recently and my area was one of the ones affected (it was mostly just the power going on and off lol) so this took me way longer than it should have to write 3 but i hope it is enjoyable regardless! i

struggled a bit to get the themes of this one across but i've had a scene like this in my mind for a while and it was a dream to get to write it for the spop flex secret solstice gift exchange :)

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra sleeps lightly. This is, perhaps, her gravest mistake.

She wakes up three times in the night — once when Adora slips into bed beside her and drapes an arm over her side, once when she presses herself into her back and pulls her against her so tightly they may as well have fused together, and once when Adora gets out of bed and doesn't come back.

The first two times, she fell back asleep within seconds. Now — well.

She waits ten minutes, then fifteen. Then twenty-five. Then her heart starts pounding far too hard for her liking, and so she shoves her head under one of Adora's upsettingly soft pillows and tries to pretend she hasn't left at all.

This, unsurprisingly, does not work. She never was good at that. Catra gives up on that after a little while and rolls onto her back to stare blankly at the ceiling, straining her ears for any sign of her at all. She can't hear her in the bathroom, or in the corridor outside, but that doesn't mean she isn't in the castle at all. It could just be a late-night snack run, which would be the logical answer any rational person would come to.

But still. This is only their second night in Bright Moon. It's more than possible that Adora has gotten sick of her and just — walked away. It's more than possible that she's decided she's too deeply evil to live with anymore, too broken somewhere deep down inside —

You're getting anxious again , Melog says conversationally.

Catra turns her head and glares at them. "Stop eavesdropping. You're supposed to be asleep."

They flick their tail at her. The tip is a sickly shade of yellow. *So are you. You woke me up.*

"She woke *me* up," she says defensively.

I know. I'm not blaming you . Melog lifts their head and nods towards the balcony. *I can sense her out there. She hasn't gone far.*

Catra relaxes instantly, and in response Melog's mane and tail turn a clear, calm blue. She hadn't even realised how tense she'd been until it melted away. "You're sure?"

That's why you can't hear her. It's windy out .

It is; that's why they'd drawn the curtains. How that was supposed to keep the wind out, Catra had no idea, but Adora had assured her it would help. She turns her head and finds them wide open, letting in soft starlight and a significantly sharper breeze than she's sure most of Bright Moon is used to.

“Huh.”

Indeed .

She finds Adora leaning against the railing of the balcony, chin resting in her hands. She looks half-asleep, and the wind is blowing loose strands of hair across her face and absolutely ruining that ponytail she insists on wearing to bed. In the moonlight, she looks almost made of silver. There are dark circles under her eyes and the faint smudges of tear tracks catching the light, and despite it all Catra has never been more in love with her than she is right now.

“Good morning,” she says.

Adora startles a little, lifting her head from her hands, but she doesn’t turn to look at her. This should not be worrying, but Catra is running on three and a half broken hours of sleep and the deep intrinsic sense that she’s done something horrifically wrong, so of course she takes it a little personally. She tucks it away between her ribs and barrels on.

“You woke me up.”

Adora's head settles back into her hands. She's been biting at her nails again. "Did I? I'm sorry."

Catra takes a step closer, tugging the blanket higher around her shoulders. "I'm a light sleeper," she says by way of explanation, like it's something Adora hasn't known since she was six and prone to nightmares. How convenient; they've known each other since they were children and suddenly she has no idea how to talk to her now that they've kissed a few times.

Adora hums, and she does look at her then — only out of the corner of her eye, but she feels it like a blow to the chest. There's something behind her eyes, something quiet and dark and grieving, and *oh* . "Yeah. Sorry. I guess I'm just — I don't know."

Catra snorts, takes another step. "I thought you'd run off in the middle of the night."

"I'd never do that to you," Adora says automatically, almost defensively. *There she is* . "I'm sorry if I worried you. I just — needed breathing space, is all."

"That's the third time you've apologised for no reason," she says, "and it's fine, Adora. It really is. I'm just being paranoid."

And, startlingly, it is. Fine, that is. She knows enough about herself to recognise now, standing out here in the bitter wind, what she's feeling.

A pause. Adora doesn’t say anything, so Catra pushes forward again. “Do you want to talk about it?”

She shakes her head once, seeming suddenly very small.

Scorpia, being a much better person than Catra, would offer her a hug. Scorpia, being a much better person than Catra, would know exactly what to say to her right now. Catra, being an idiot, steps closer until they’re inches away from each other and mumbles, “So what’re we doing?”

Adora’s jaw works. Her eyes stay fixed on the sky, like if she stares hard enough she can disintegrate whatever it is that’s hurting her. “Watching the stars.”

It takes a lot of effort for Catra to tear her gaze off her, but she manages it somehow, following her gaze all the way to the skyline and the moonlight on the cliffs outside the castle. The sky is clear and cloudless, and all three of the moons are just about visible on the surface of the lake. It is, by all accounts, a beautiful night. Adora is, to someone who doesn’t know all her tells, know *her* like the back of their hand, fine.

Stars , Catra thinks. *Stars, stars, stars.* She wouldn’t be out here contemplating them like this if they weren’t driving needles inbetween her lungs. She wouldn’t be avoiding looking at her so obviously if she wasn’t in pain.

“Adora,” she says, “what happened?”

She snorts, head dipping from her hands. “That obvious, huh?”

Catra musters up her best smirk. “I know you.”

Adora looks at her again, then, with eyes that are far too hollow. “Yeah, you really do,” she says softly, fondly.

She looks so deeply in love that it’s kind of hard to remember what they were talking about in the first place. Catra scrambles for something to say and comes up empty, hyper-aware of the gentle, lovestruck way she’s watching her now, head tilted to the side, the corners of her mouth kicking up into a loose smile.

“Stop changing the subject,” is what comes out eventually, inbetween no small amount of choking. “No flirting. Answer the question, loser.”

Adora turns to face her fully, elbows still resting against the railing. She looks almost deific like this, outlined by moonlight and the landscape below. “What? I’m just saying —”

Catra steps right up to her so they’re nose to nose and fixes her with a half-assed glare that cuts her off completely. She stifles a laugh that sounds like it clawed its way up her throat instead,

leaning back against the railing. It's a poor attempt at acting casual, but there's something to be said for the fact that she's trying. Catra gives up on clinging to the blanket around her shoulders — it's not like she really needed it, anyway — and slips her arms around Adora's waist instead, tugging her closer.

"Stop deflecting."

She smiles. "Deflecting what?"

Catra can't stop herself from grinning too. "You know exactly what you're doing. Now shut up and talk to me. I want to help."

Adora hums, in the process of leaning in for a kiss. "Mm. I don't have the slightest clue as to what you're referring to. Mind enlightening me?"

She tilts her head down until Catra can feel her breath on her lips and waits there, waiting for her to meet her inbetween.

She gives in. Just for a few seconds, but she's nothing if not an understanding girlfriend.

A few seconds turns into ten minutes or so, and then Catra decides she's had enough of her stalling and pulls away. Adora makes a small noise of protest, but doesn't chase her — which is a pretty good sign, all things considered.

"Okay," she manages, "kissing time over. Now, if you don't mind —"

"I do mind," Adora huffs. "I mind so much. You have no idea how much I mind."

There's no bite behind it. Catra raises an eyebrow and she huffs again.

"I'm just — I'm fine, really. I promise you that I'm fine, Catra."

That — well. Promises are promises. Catra's eyebrows only shoot up further. "Okay," she says, "and that's why you were out here crying on the balcony in the middle of the night."

"Uh huh," Adora says, scowling a little. "Catra. Please."

"You don't have to, like, divulge all your trauma. I just want to know if I can help."

That makes her deflate. Only slightly, but it's an opening. Catra presses a kiss to the corner of her mouth and steps away before she can try for more.

"Um," she says, and her voice comes out much weaker than it did before. "When you asked me what happened —"

Catra pictures Perfuma in her mind, sitting cross-legged opposite her in the grass in the valley that used to be at the heart of the Crimson Waste, and takes a deep breath. Maybe she is right about some stuff, sometimes. "You don't have to tell me. I'm sorry if I made you feel like I was pressuring you into anything. I'm just pulling therapy bullshit out of my ass and hoping it works."

"Where'd you get that one from?"

She shrugs. "Perfuma. I figure if I just regurgitate things she says I'll get there eventually."

Adora huffs out a laugh, then pauses, considering her. Her thinking face is almost unbearably cute — eyebrows drawn together, nose scrunched up, lips pressed into a thin line. Kissing her would be bad form, though, so Catra steps away from her and leans back against the railing to give her room to think.

"I guess I just need to be distracted," she says finally. "I — I came out here to get away from my thoughts, but —" Adora pauses, swallowing thickly. "The sky is just one big reminder."

Catra folds her arms, unable to stop herself from smiling a little. "And you're too stubborn to go back inside."

"I am *not* ."

She rolls her eyes. "Well. I can do distractions."

Adora's face lights up. "Do we get to kiss again?"

They do, in fact, kiss again. And, an hour or two later, Catra even manages to get Adora back into bed, which she considers to be quite a significant achievement. She lies curled up against her side and listens to her heartbeat, halfway to sleep already. If she had any more energy she'd be watching Adora instead.

"Catra?"

"Mm."

"Can we talk about it now?"

Catra yawns. “Yeah, ‘course.”

“No, wait, you’re half-asleep, never m—”

“Adora,” she mumbles, “I’m listening. Doesn’t matter. Start talking, loser.”

She feels, rather than hears, her laughter. “Okay, okay. Um.”

Adora sits up, dislodging Catra’s head, and pulls her knees up to her chest. Catra stays sprawled out on the covers, far too comfortable to get up. Adora’s hands find their way to her tail and start toying with it anxiously. It’s been a habit of hers ever since they were children. Catra never protests.

“So, when I…” her voice breaks. She clears her throat. “When I tried to sleep. I, um. I couldn’t stop thinking about the stars.”

She’s incredibly forthcoming. Catra wonders if she’d be this open with anyone else.

“The stars, which I… the stars, which we can see because of me. Because I — because the sword broke.”

Oh.

Catra opens her mouth to say something — she isn't sure what, exactly, but *something* . She'd known the original sword was gone, of course; she isn't stupid. But Adora talking about the *why* is new. She clamps her mouth shut before she can make anything worse and gestures for her to continue, wincing a little when Adora's hands on her tail tug a little too tightly.

"I broke it because — well, you know. Light Hope was going to use me to, uh. To fuck up everything. But I couldn't stop her from pulling us out of Despondos." Adora swallows, staring downward. "And then Prime found us."

"If you think that was your fault you're insane," Catra says before she can stop herself.

Adora bursts into laughter. That's something. That's good.

She rises onto her elbows, yawning again. "I'm serious. What else were you supposed to do?"

"I know, I know." Adora props herself up on her hands, tipping her head back until she's staring at the ceiling. "Trust me, I know. I guess I just — sometimes it —" She lets go of Catra's tail, presses her hands over her heart instead. "I feel it. Here. The weight of all of it."

She doesn’t really know what to say to that.

Catra shuffles over until she’s lying with her head in her lap. Adora’s hands go straight for her ears, like she knew they would. She’s never really been good at the whole kind words and reassurance thing, but she *is* good at this. Adora’s loved it since they were small children.

“Yeah,” she says quietly. “Yeah. I get that.”

She looks up and finds Adora smiling down at her, lips quirked up in that soft way that suggests she’s very, very in love. She’d looked at her like that in the Heart, like she’d hung the stars in the sky just for her. Catra shifts a little, suddenly uncomfortable.

“I didn’t know about that. Why you broke the sword, I mean.”

Adora makes a face. “Yeah, well. I guess I just — have a thing about telling people the details. It fucking sucked.”

“Yeah, I got that,” Catra grins. Adora wrinkles her nose harder, but she’s still smiling at her, gentle as ever.

They lapse into comfortable silence. Eventually, somehow, Adora falls asleep like that — half propped up on pillows, half sprawled across the bed — and Catra stays in her lap, listening to the deep, even sounds of her breathing. She finds it easier to sleep like this,

she'd confessed, like they were kids again dozing off in classes or reading books together by flashlight under thin Horde blankets.

Catra lies awake for a long time, far longer than she'd expected to. She shuts her eyes out of respect for the quiet, threading her fingers through Adora's around her shoulders, and thinks, *I hope you feel as safe with me as I feel with you* .

How could she not ? Melog hums, half-asleep.

She smiles to herself.

End Notes

coughs hacks splutters

please leave a comment/kudos if you enjoyed!! you can find me @nonbinarychaoticstupid on tumblr if you want to say hi :) (and while you're there please please check out my pinned post)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!